

CHANNEL TEARDOWN SERIES | SEPTEMBER 2026

HOW FYI GREW TO 39K IN NINE MONTHS

A strategy breakdown of the Malayalam explainer channel FYI
and the playbook you can reuse

1.14M TOTAL VIEWS

8 LONG-FORM VIDEOS

~32 SHORTS

Data: vidiQ, pulled 26 Sep 2026 | Prepared by Mundus Cognitus AI Studio x Cognitus Learn

The Channel at a Glance

FYI: Kerala society and politics, explained in Malayalam. Launched December 2025.

39K

SUBSCRIBERS

1.14M

LIFETIME VIEWS

40

VIDEOS

~88%

VIEWS FROM LONG-FORM

THE VIDEO THAT TRIGGERED THIS REPORT

A **Deeper Analysis of Kerala Migration** (20:29) went live on 25 Sep 2026 and was at **51.6K views, 1.46K likes and 206 comments** within about a day.

It was gaining around **2,600 views an hour**, the fastest start the channel has had. It follows an average Kerala graduate from a study-abroad agency office to life overseas, and asks what agents will not answer: loan repayment, rankings, visa rejections, post-study work routes and brain drain.

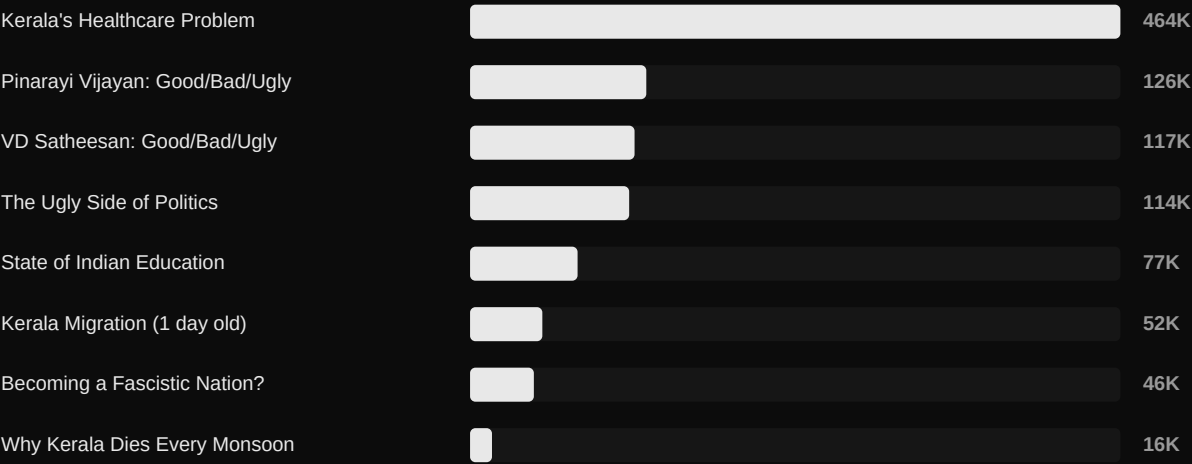
THE POSITIONING IN ONE LINE

Most Malayalam political content is TV-news shouting or party-aligned commentary. FYI presents itself as the **calm, researched explainer**, closer to Dhruv Rathee or Johnny Harris than to a news channel.

Its own description says it plainly: *"This is not an anti-abroad video. It's a guide to asking the right questions."* The brand promise is neutral information, not a side.

Few Uploads, Big Videos

Roughly one 13-20 minute documentary a month. Views per long-form video below.



WHAT THE NUMBERS SAY

The 8 long videos bring in about **1.01M of 1.14M total views**. One video, the healthcare explainer (464K views, 22K likes, about 2K comments), accounts for **roughly 40% of all channel views**.

That is the usual pattern for documentary channels: one breakout carries the channel, and each new upload is another chance at the next one. Upload rarely, but make every upload good enough to break out.

Topics That Hit Every Malayali

Three themes, each tied to something viewers already feel strongly about.

THEME	VIDEOS	WHY IT WORKS
Kerala systems	Healthcare, education, monsoon, migration	Affects every family, so it gets forwarded in family WhatsApp groups
Politician profiles	Pinarayi Vijayan, VD Satheesan (Good / Bad / Ugly)	Covers both sides, so both camps watch and argue in the comments
National politics	Ugly side of politics, fascism question	Big-question framing that invites debate

TIMING AND BALANCE

The politician profiles came out in **April 2026, around the Kerala Assembly election season**. They cover the CPI(M) chief minister *and* the Congress opposition leader.

Covering both sides pulls in each side's supporters. Those two videos have 845-888 comments each, and comment fights push reach while the channel itself stays neutral.

PACKAGING

- Reused title formats: "**X, Explained**", "**The GOOD. The BAD. The UGLY.**", "**Why Kerala Keeps...?**"
- English titles on Malayalam videos: searchable and reaches NRIs and diaspora viewers
- Long, SEO-style descriptions written as lists of questions the video answers

Shorts as Trailers, Brands as Revenue

PHASE 1: SEARCHING FOR A NICHE (DEC 2025 - FEB 2026)

Random general-knowledge Shorts: diamonds, an immortal jellyfish, Venezuela, green energy. **1.5K-4.7K views each**. Nothing tied them to a long-form library.

PHASE 2: SHORTS THAT PROMOTE THE LONG VIDEOS (APR 2026 ONWARD)

Almost every Short is now a clip from a long video titled "**| Watch the full video**". The best one (Sonam Wangchuk / NEET) peaks at about **10.5K views**. They work as trailers pointing viewers to the long video, not as a growth channel of their own.

Weak spot: several Shorts are titled just "Watch the full video on youtube!", which wastes their search and click-through potential.

MONETISATION: BRAND DEALS

Every description carries "*We create organic contents for your brand*" with a Google Form link. Ad revenue from one video a month is small, so the channel's reach is being used to sell content-making services to brands.

Six Moves You Can Reuse

What to copy from FYI, in order of impact.

01**Own a regional audience with a calm-explainer angle**

Pick a language or region where the space is full of loud, partisan content, and be the researched, neutral voice.

02**Upload rarely, polish every video**

One 15-20 minute video a month on a problem every family has can carry a whole channel. Aim each upload at being the breakout.

03**Cover both sides of divisive topics**

Paired profiles and balanced framing bring in both camps. Comment fights boost reach while the channel stays neutral.

04**Tie releases to the news cycle**

Elections, monsoon floods, visa rule changes, budget day. Publish when people are already searching.

05**Cut 3-5 Shorts from every long video**

Give each Short its own hook title. Never ship a Short titled "watch full video".

06**Add a brand-deal link from day one**

Put an enquiry form in every description so reach turns into revenue before ad income matters.

Where FYI Is Exposed

Each weakness is a gap a competing channel could use.

01**Credibility slip from AI visuals**

The newest description apologises for AI-generated maps with inaccuracies. For a channel that sells credibility, errors like this damage trust fast. Fact-check every visual, AI or not.

02**Dependence on one hit**

About 40% of lifetime views come from a single video. Monthly uploads mean long gaps between chances at the next breakout.

03**Shorts not pulling their weight**

Trailer Shorts with generic titles cap at around 10K views. Standalone, hook-first Shorts could grow the channel on their own.

04**Political topics carry platform and legal risk**

Titles like "Why Government want Sonam Wangchuk dead?!" push toward sensationalism, which conflicts with the neutral brand and can draw strikes or backlash.

Study the Pattern. Then Build Your Own.

FYI shows that a regional channel can reach 39K subscribers in nine months with one careful documentary a month, balanced framing, and Shorts that point back to the long videos. The formula is repeatable in any language or niche.

Want a teardown of another channel?

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Figures from vidIQ as of 26 Sep 2026. View counts change daily.

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